
“The goal to strive for is a
poor government but a **rich
people.**”

ANDREW JOHNSON, QUOTED IN *ANDREW JOHNSON, PLEBEIAN
AND PATRIOT* BY ROBERT WATSON WINSTON (1928)

The assassination of Abraham Lincoln thrust Andrew Johnson into the spotlight, conferring on him a role that he had never been expected to play. Born into poverty in North Carolina, he had no formal schooling. Instead, he was apprenticed to a tailor at an age when most children would still have been attending lessons.

In his teens, Johnson abandoned the apprenticeship and ran away with his brother to Tennessee, where he found work as a tailor in the town of Greeneville in the east of the state. This was a land of smallholders, who had little in common with the enslaving estate owners of the deep South. It was these people, the smallholders, whose views Johnson would represent over the course of his political career. In contrast, he always maintained a deep-seated resentment against the great estate owners.

In Greeneville, the young Johnson met and married a shoemaker's daughter, Eliza McCardle, who is said to have taught him writing and arithmetic, and encouraged him in his political ambitions. In 1829, at just 20, he became a municipal alderman, and four years later he was elected town mayor. A talent for oratory took him to the Tennessee House of Representatives two years after that. Over the next three decades his political career went from strength to strength. He was elected to the lower house of Congress in 1843, then became Governor of Tennessee. In 1857, he entered the Senate as a Democrat, and was serving in that capacity at the outbreak of the Civil War. Although a Southerner, Johnson was fiercely opposed to secession, a cause he identified with the planters